FUTURE TRENDS AI

DEFENCE



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INDIA AT THE CROSSROADS OF AN ALGORITHM WAR

AS AI CHANGES THE CHARACTER OF WARFARE, ONE MUST REMEMBER THAT IT IS ABOUT SURVIVING AND WINNING TOMORROW'S WARS WITHOUT LOSING OUR SOULS, COUNTERING NON-STATE ACTORS AND SECURITY THREATS PECULIAR TO INDIA

Artificial Intelligence is becoming the most transformative, defining and all-pervasive technology of our era. It is no longer just a tool for innovation, but fast becoming a competitive battleground between nations who see AI as a strategic asset, with both economic and military advantages. The AI race for strategic superiority is also a geopolitical contest, seen as crucial for economic dominance, national security and global influence. It is a high-stakes contest. The competition is not just about technological capability and smarter algorithms but about building the foundational ecosystem and shaping standards and norms of governance to control a technology that could redefine power structures.

Uncertainties surrounding AI and its military applications have sparked discussions focusing on its impact on warfare, and how it is fundamentally rewriting the rules and reshaping the dynamics and ethics of war. The implications of battlefield use of AI—how policymakers should navigate its inherent trade-offs and what legal and moral safeguards are needed—is being hotly debated.

War by algorithm refers to using AI and algorithms for military tasks, such as using vast data for intelligence and targeting, enhancing situational awareness, predictive analysis, faster decision-making, use in autonomous weapon systems, controlling information flow, influencing public opinion and shaping narratives. Offering immense advantages, AI is transforming the character of war, and is challenging legal, ethical and conceptual understandings of warfare itself, bringing with it new forms of risks.

Key challenges of using AI systems in defence include data-security concerns, algorithmic bias, ethical implications of autonomous weapons, unpredictability and unreliability, unintended consequences, accountability and responsibility. With the role of AI in identifying and engaging targets, witnessed in recent conflicts, we may be moving towards more invisible and insidious forms of automated decision-making in warfare. Will AI enable killer robots to stalk the battlefield, dispensing algorithmically determined death and destruction in future? As